

In May, 1966, the World Health Organization was authorized to initiate a global campaign to eradicate smallpox. The goal was to eliminate the disease in one decade. Because similar projects for malaria and yellow fever had failed, few believed that smallpox could actually be eradicated, but eleven years after the initial organization of the campaign, no cases were reported in the field.

The strategy was not only to provide mass vaccinations but also to isolate patients with active smallpox in order to contain the spread of the disease and to break the chain of human transmission. Rewards for reporting smallpox assisted in motivating the public to aid health workers. One by one, each smallpox victim was sought out, removed from contact with others, and treated. At the same time, the entire village the victim had lived was vaccinated.

Today smallpox is no longer a threat to humanity. Routine vaccinations have been stopped worldwide.